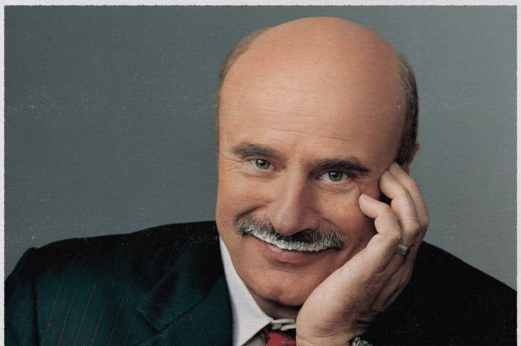










a runaway success that the national dairy checkoff organization took a page from California and licensed the campaign to run nationwide.

Around that time, MilkPEP, the national milk processor checkoff, joined the battle to make milk cool. Their contribution? Print ads featuring celebrities wearing milk mustaches. "You could not open a People magazine, or a Parade, without seeing a milk mustache," said Kikke Riedel of MilkPEP, who noted that the two campaigns joined forces in 1997 by tagging the photos with "Got Milk?" The ads, photographed by Annie Leibovitz, didn't just harness celebrity worship; they curated it, picking stars at the peak of their popularity such as a smizing Tyra Banks, Buffy's Sarah Michelle Gellar, the band Hanson, and athletes like New York Knicks player Patrick Ewing.

In Got Milk's heyday, the World Wide Web was in its infancy. Social media hadn't been dreamed up. So for A-listers, publicity opportunities like milk mustache ads—which were eye-popping headshots, distributed in national magazines—were golden. "We paid them very little money," Riedel said of the stars. "They would call us and beg to be in the campaign." TV gossip shows like Entertainment Tonight sometimes swooped in to film the photo shoot, doubling everyone's exposure. (An aside: Riedel now feels comfortable sharing that the mustaches were made with a "proprietary mix" of milk, ice cream, and sour cream.)

At the turn of the millennium, milk ads were ubiquitous. "Got Milk?" was printed on boxes of Cheerios and Oreos. Mattel produced a Got Milk? Hot Wheels toy truck, and toy stores stocked Got Milk? Barbies dressed in Holstein-patterned overalls.